

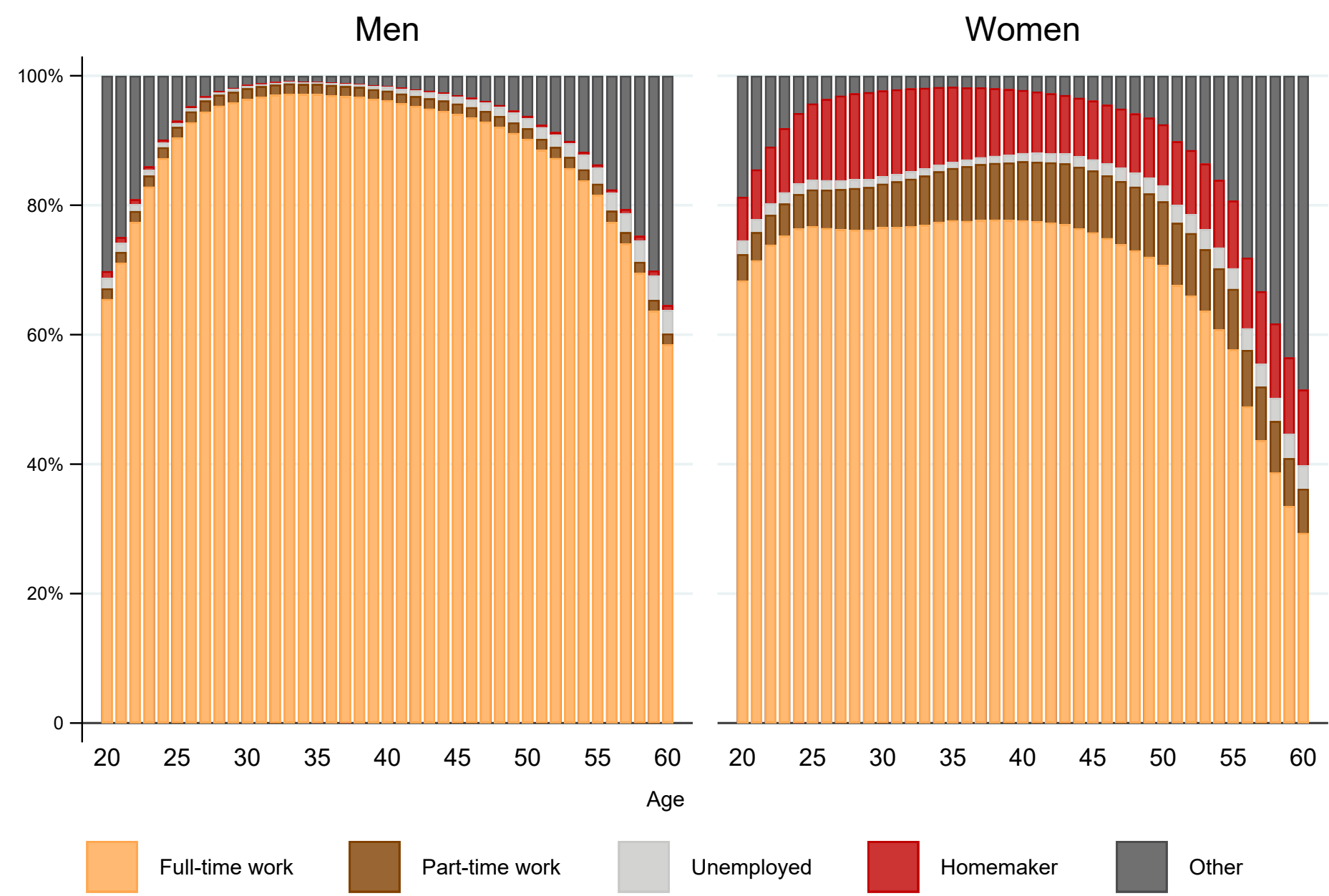
Gender Disparities at Work over the Lifecourse: Job Satisfaction & Employment Histories

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Motivation: *Why aren't women more dissatisfied?*

- Relevance of job satisfaction: overall well-being, productivity, future quits, abseteism (Akerlof et al. 1988; Clegg 1983; Oswald et al. 2015).
- Gender satisfaction *paradox* from early findings (Hodson 1989; Clark 1997) confirmed across countries (cohorts).
- Explanation: women hold *lower expectations* shaped by gender norms (Clark 1997, Perugini & Vladislavljević 2019): no gap if exposed to more gender equal settings (higher education, male-dominated occupations).
- Critical blind spot: All existing studies observe only current workers & miss early exiters.

Gender Differences in Work Histories

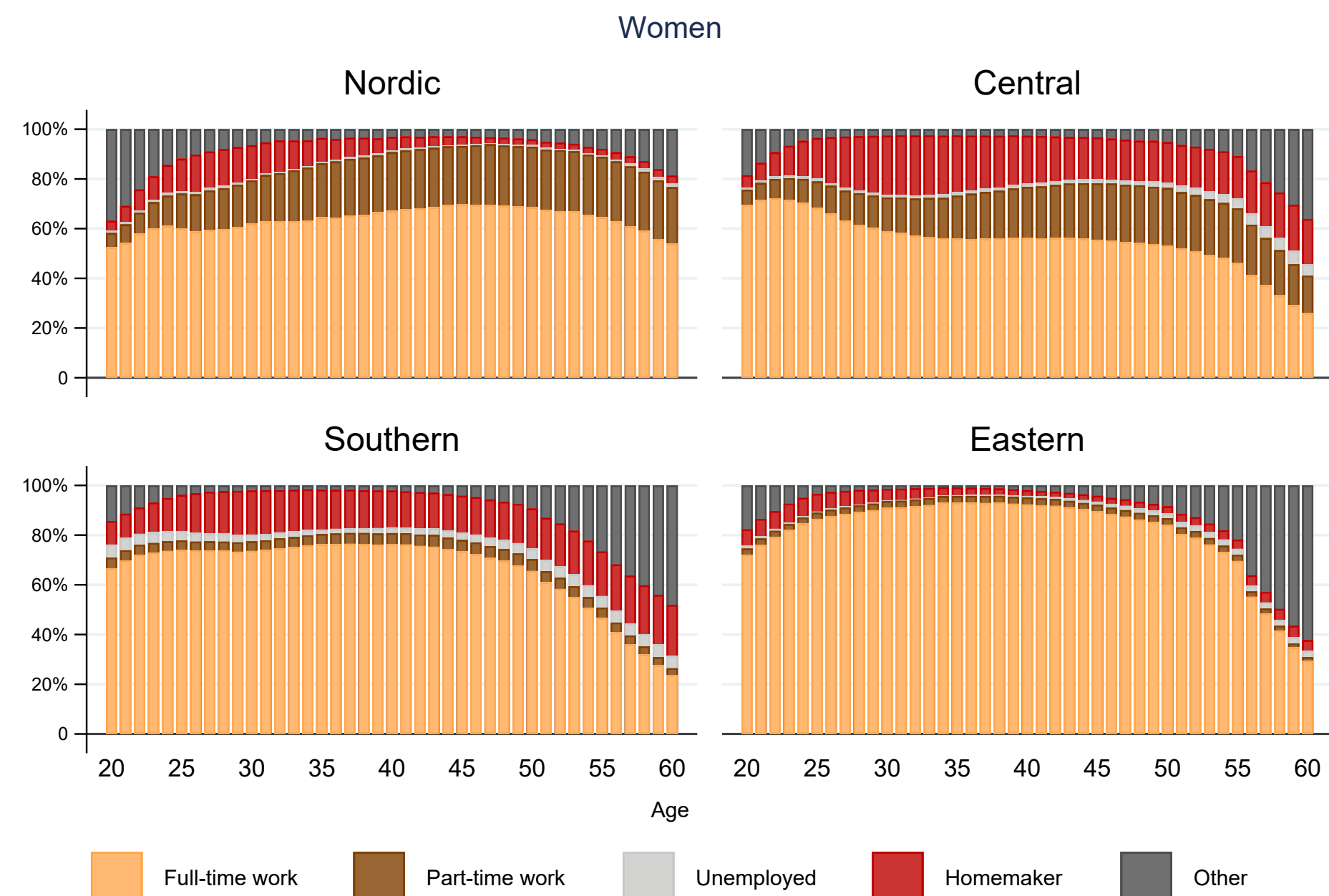


Only if ever worked. Stacked bars show proportion of person-years in each status.

Hypothesis

- Dissatisfied workers exit LM earlier.
- Exit response to dissatisfaction is gendered and norm-driven.
- Least satisfied women exit — easier exit where traditional norms make it culturally viable (unless state socialism).
- Dissatisfied men have no equivalent exit option, regardless of norms.
- Consequence: biased pool of current workers:
 - Satisfied men & women: equally observable.
 - Dissatisfied men: equally observable.
 - Dissatisfied women: under-observed in traditional settings.

Female Work Histories: Regional Peculiarities

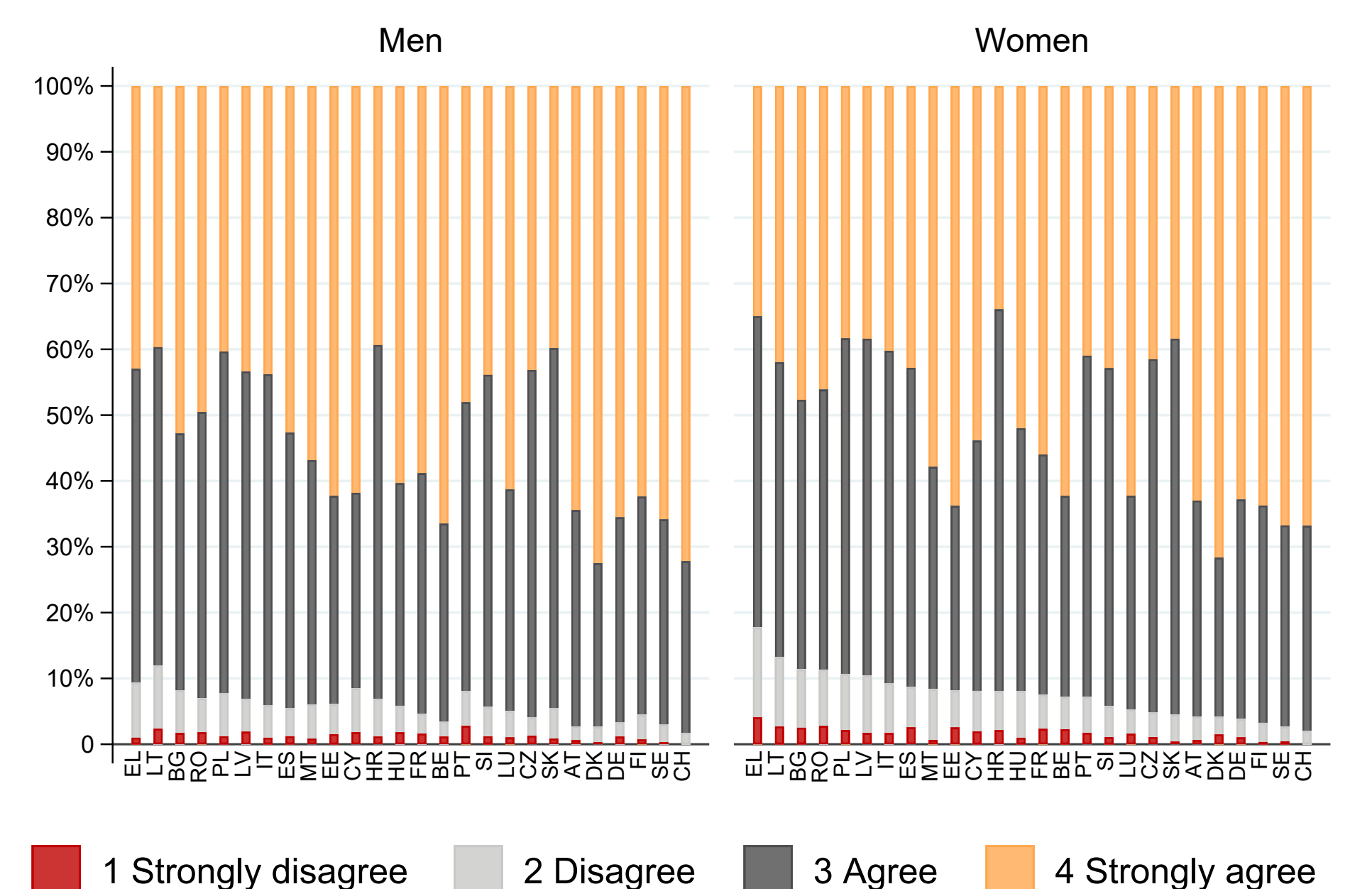


Nordic: DK, FI, SE. **Central:** AT, BE, CH, DE, FR, LU. **Southern:** CY, ES, GR, HR, IT, MT, PT, SI. **Eastern:** BG, CZ, EE, HU, LT, LV, PL, RO, SK.

Data

- Survey of Health, Ageing and Retirement in Europe SHARE: panel of individuals aged 50+, waves 1–10 (2004–2025), all EU countries.
- Full retrospective life history: childhood, children, partners, moves, jobs.
- Sample: Over 28 000 individuals with completed working careers.
- First paper to examine gender gaps in satisfaction with the main job of one's career (the one that took up most of your working life).
- Compared to studies on current job we observe a more complete pool of workers (those who left LM early: early job = main job).

Job Satisfaction by Country



Answers to: “All things considered I was satisfied with my main job”.

Gender Gap: Satisfaction with Main Job

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Women	−0.037*** (0.010)	−0.032*** (0.011)	−0.042*** (0.010)	−0.038*** (0.010)
Education years		0.011*** (0.002)	0.005*** (0.002)	0.005*** (0.002)
Sector (ref. Private)				
Public			0.055*** (0.018)	0.057*** (0.018)
Self-employed			0.055** (0.025)	0.052** (0.025)
Status (ref. Full-time)				
Part-time			−0.053** (0.020)	−0.053** (0.020)
Number of jobs before main (ref. 0)				
1				0.018 (0.013)
2				0.048** (0.017)
3+				0.062*** (0.020)
Observations	28781	28781	28781	28781
R-squared	0.047	0.053	0.068	0.069

Standard errors in parentheses

* $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

OLS, Outcome: 'I was satisfied with my main job' 1=strongly disagree, 2=disagree, 3=agree, 4=strongly agree. Sample: 50+ with completed working careers. Controls: (1)-(4) country+cohort fixed effects, (3)-(4) occupation (10 ISCO), (4) gaps+disabilities before main job. Clustered SE: country level.

- Women less likely to report satisfaction with main job, robust to controls.

Dissatisfied Women Worked Shorter?

- LM response to dissatisfaction is gendered & norm-driven.
- Good proxy for gender norms? Values Surveys, ELGE (Perugini & Vladislavljević 2019), Maternal education (variation across & within countries).

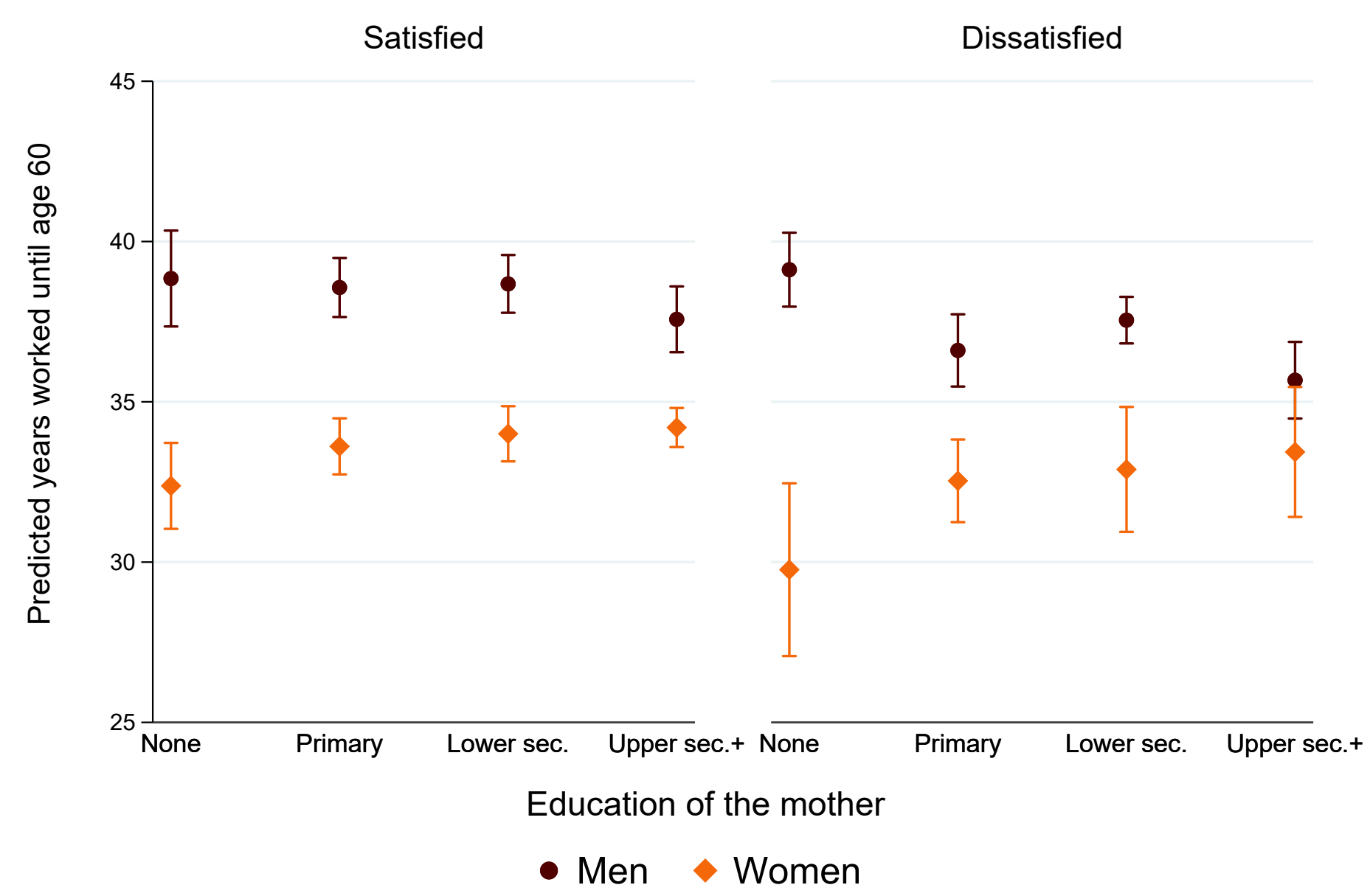
	(1)	(2)	(3)
Women	−4.727*** (0.710)	−4.695*** (0.700)	−6.469*** (1.343)
Dissatisfied	−1.416*** (0.276)	−1.087*** (0.305)	0.276 (0.626)
Women × Dissatisfied		−0.555 (0.519)	−2.890*** (0.849)
Mother's education (ref. None)			
Primary			−0.514 (0.733)
Lower sec.			−0.570 (0.837)
Upper sec.+More			−1.326 (0.898)
Women × Dissatisfied × Primary			3.779*** (1.036)
Women × Dissatisfied × Lower sec.			2.909*** (0.968)
Women × Dissatisfied × Upper sec.+More			4.027*** (1.200)
Observations	26112	26112	21537
R-squared	0.289	0.289	0.295

Standard errors in parentheses

* $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Heterogeneity by Gender Norms

⇒ Marginal effects: Predicted years worked until 60 for men and women, by satisfaction with main job and level of maternal education



- Traditional context (mother with no education): men work more, women work less (large gap).
- Egalitarian context (mother with higher education): more symmetric LM attachment - men also work less.
- Reduced male breadwinner obligations - men feel more able to exit, switch, or downshift LM activity when dissatisfied.

Conclusions

- Women are less likely to report satisfaction with the job central to their career (robust across specifications).
- Dissatisfaction may be associated with early labour market exits.
- Gender gap in exits due to dissatisfaction is differentiated by broader gender norms context.
- Standard cross-sectional data underestimate the gender satisfaction gap — the most dissatisfied women missing, because they exited early.

References & Acknowledgement

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